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HON 211A: Final Paper

Metaphysics: What is my theory of the meaning and purpose of the cosmos and the place of the human being in it?

Whenever I begin to think about my purpose in life, I first begin by considering my identity, positionalities, and what principles I have unwavering belief in. I think the most important consideration in defining my theory of meaning is to consider what experiences constitute and heavily influence my perspective towards life. Coming from the perspective of an individual raised in an educated, protective, and religious family, I believe my cosmology bears a strong weight of my upbringing. To explain my cosmology or my view of the contemporary world, I would probably use the metaphor of a coffee sapling, where a human being is a coffee sapling and the world is its growing ground. When a coffee seed is first planted it is raised in a nursery until it grows into a sapling, then it is transplanted into the soil. This is how I categorize the “meaning” development process of an individual. When a child is first born into this world, they are first raised under the protection, care, and attention of their family and loved ones. It is during this process that the child starts developing a basic understanding of the world, i.e. the ground rules, and this understanding is mostly given to them by their families. When the child metaphorically reaches the age of “transplantation” that is when they first get the opportunity of exploring their environment not filterless but with more freedom. This is what I term the beginning of developing a sense of self.

To put this metaphor into perspective, I think I have only recently moved into my “transplantation” stage. I personally believe that each human being in society has a role to play and their role is typically decided not by their preferences but by their surroundings. In class we have talked a lot about the inside-out or the outside-in perspective and I think in this case the outside-in is more prevalent. In the contemporary world, I see myself placed in a position where I find myself accountable not only for my own actions past and present but also the actions of my ancestors. A lot of what I do and understand is shaped by how people did it in the past but there is no longer a shared sense of community. I think the biggest problem with the contemporary world is that we are spiraling down the stairs of cynicism and we have become skeptical of every little detail in the world. This is ironic because our social imaginary has become so filtered that we are becoming too picky about the minute details and completely ignoring the necessary details. This is not to say that all human beings are experiencing ontological dizziness but something I would like to term as a lost sense of “purpose.” The contemporary world has significantly advanced and we have way more opportunities than our ancestors and yet we seem to not be faring well despite being “nurtured” as saplings and carefully “transplanted” with more knowledge on how to survive. I don’t think the problem lies in the nurturing or the

transplantation stage because that experience is unique and non-overlapping for every single individual. However, I do think that the “soil” or the world that we are entering is too depleted in its sense of “culture,” “community,” and “shared beliefs” to provide us with the essential nutrients to survive.

To define my cosmology, I might be dwelling ever so slightly into idealism but this is how I wish to view the world and the placement of human beings within it. History has shown that implementing a chain of being or trying to order living beings on a spectrum has been faced with resistance and has often led to major fallouts. Even though I do not agree with ordering living forms on a spectrum like the Neoplatonic chain of being, I do think that it has a deeper, more implementable meaning. The major issue contemporary humans are facing is the lack of a center of gravity, a communal purpose, and I think this should be the basis of social organization. Order in the contemporary cosmos can be restored if each human being is aware of the goal they are working toward. I would like to draw inspiration from the communal values of Native Americans. I appreciate the structure of the social organization in tribal societies because there is no sense of superiority or inferiority in where a human stands on the social hierarchy. Each individual has a defined task and by diligently performing their task they are contributing to the community. Even though I take the example of the native communities, I understand the restrictions of implementing such forms of social organization on a broader scale. I think our first step towards redefining the order in our contemporary cosmos can be to consider the importance of each individual's role and contribution to society. It takes water, nutrients, rich soil, and sunlight to help coffee saplings to achieve their maximum potential and if there is a dearth in any of these aspects we will not achieve the intended result.

To conclude my discussion of cosmology, I would like to present the two different ways in which I predict the destiny of human beings on the earth and in the rest of the cosmos. Even though I cannot describe the scenario in a single term, I would like to call it “directionless.” If the human race is unable to find a common goal and move toward greater disembeddedness, I think humanity will reach a point where even the “survival of the fittest” would also be a bleak chance. Humans are inherently social beings and disembeddedness is inherently alienating, therefore I do not see a future where individualism goes hand-in-hand with a flourishing society. I am not trying to say that there can be a complete omission of competitive spirit in the world and having a sense of “individualism.” However, if we wish to survive as a race and still be considered a “society,” I think we will have to move past the greed of “self-first.” Shifting on to my second and more idealist scenario, I would like to call it “utopia.” This scenario constitutes what I think would be an ideal and progressive way forward for the human race. We need to start by discovering traditions or values that bring us together on a massive scale. This seems fictional at present considering the immense diversity and conflict within the human race, however, I think we need a little flavor of enchantment and an acceptance of mythos in some sense. It is impossible to have each human on the face of the earth to come to a shared understanding of the

world, however, we may formulate some ground rules. Even though not all human beings have strong religious behaviors and quite a few individuals are drawn away from any form of mythos in our scientific world, I do believe that the creation of the universe at this point in time is not explainable through science. Therefore, we can as a race just attempt to accept that there is a central power governing the cosmos. I think this will be humanity's leap from "purposeless" to a "work in progress." I think my terminology for this scenario might seem like a misfit, however, I do not mean utopia in a literal sense. My definition of utopia in this scenario is when humanity transitions from the "age of whatever" to the "age of belonging."

Epistemology: What is my theory of truth or knowledge?

The theory of truth and knowledge is quite an intriguing consideration for me. I don't think I have ever consciously reflected on what makes things truthful. I feel like the word "truth" has become more and more individualized in the contemporary world. The way an individual defines truth is heavily influenced by their outlook toward life, the importance of the action in question, and their sense of self. I would like to explain my theory of what is knowable through a very simple example. When we are younger, I am certain that our parents told us something that was not necessarily true in "reality" but we still had a strong belief in its presence. For instance, my parents told me that the present I received on Christmas was from Santa. Even though Santa does not exist in the real world, I had a strong belief in this "truth" as a child. Therefore, I think the truth has a lot to do with belief and will. I am not certain if I can accurately define what is truthful, however, I do have a layered understanding of what I consider to be truthful and knowable.

Truth for me is not a concept that is clearly distinguishable into the black or white categories. I see truth as a very arbitrary and layered concept. My understanding of truth is certainly influenced by my metaphysics because I allow room for mythos. While history has seen a lot of debate tracing the truth in mythology and weighing it on the scale of whether it is believable, I do not think every truthful or believable experience has a scientific or logical explanation. I am not trying to say that I do not reason what I consider to be truthful, but I do think that some experiences in life go beyond the realms of scientific reasoning. My theory of truthfulness and what is knowable works in four stages: understanding, questioning, reflecting, and accepting. My first stage for "measuring truthfulness" is trying to understand the action or concept in its given context. For instance, I wear a "kara" or bangle on my wrist as a member of the Sikh religion. Elders in my family explained to me that this "bangle" is not only a gesture of solidarity with my community but it is also supposed to give me "strength." If I were to measure the "truthfulness" of this belief on the spectrum of science, then I would probably consider it a delusional claim and prohibit myself from partaking in this tradition. However, I try to understand the roots of the tradition in the context of both the community culture and also the time period of the tradition's establishment. My second stage of the determinants of truthfulness is questioning and I consider

this stage a result of my upbringing in the post-modern world. My acceptance of mythos does not guarantee my belief in an action, because I like to consider the “why” behind an action before classifying it as “believable.” To draw evidence from a personal anecdote, my grandmother once narrated a “saakhi” to me. A “saakhi” is a religious story in the Sikh religion that demonstrates a core religious value or a lesson taught by our gurus. Guru Nanak Dev Ji is the first guru in the Sikh religion and the saakhi recounts his visit to Mecca in the early 16th century. The gist of the story is that Guru Nanak Dev Ji was resting under a tree with his feet pointed towards Kaaba (a religious shrine), and a passerby asked Guru Ji to not point his feet towards Kaaba. Listening to the passerby, Guru Ji requested them to shift his feet to the direction where he wouldn’t be pointing towards God. As soon as he moved Guru Ji’s feet, the direction of the Kaaba was also turned. From the perspective of a scientific individual, this story would be classified as delusional. Even though I do not believe the story in the sense that Kaaba would physically have changed direction, I do think it has a deeper meaning of teaching the community that God is universal and not restricted to a singular place. In my determinants of truth, faith plays a key role.

Moving on to the third and fourth stages of believability, I think my acceptance of a thing as truth is heavily influenced by my “reflection” stage. My period of reflection involves not only an analysis of the scenario and its importance to my definition of what is really “real,” but also how it would alter my understanding of what is knowable. Although this might be a filtered way of looking at truth, I think I need to strongly identify with something and to see the conviction in its presentation for me to consider it “truth.” My belief and participation in religious traditions does not stem from them being “obligatory” but from the fact that they serve a bigger purpose in enhancing my understanding of the world. My final stage of believability is acceptance, and this is the stage where I would see the most room for ambiguity. Acceptance is the stage where I see myself drawing upon the evidence from the past three stages to support my analysis of whether I choose to believe something. This is not to say that I am never delusional or I have never had an awakening, but I do understand where that belief was coming from. In a nutshell, faith and flexibility open a plethora of doors into at least exploring what is “knowable.”

Ethics: What is my theory of right behavior?

I think my theory of right behavior is a midway point between radical liberalism and radical socialism. The way I define a “good life” for myself and for others is one in which all individuals have equal opportunity to flourish and express themselves. My ideal of a “good life” is one where I am able to achieve a balance between thinking of both self and communal good. I think this foundation “good life” comes from my appreciation of the beliefs imparted in my upbringing through a practice of the Sikh religion. One of the biggest teachings of the Sikh religion is giving back to the community. At every Sikh temple of worship, there is food service at all times of the day. All individuals regardless of their social status, religion, or race are welcome to eat a meal.

The meals are provided three times a day and they are free of cost. I think this practice accurately sums up my understanding of a “good life” because it demonstrates the responsibility taken up by the individuals preparing the meal and feeding the community. They not only recognize their contribution to the community by cooking the food but also understand the contribution of the community and its solidarity to their well-being.

To shed some light on what I think is the “right” way to go for the community, I think all human beings need to take two things into consideration: what can I do for the community and what can I gain from the community. In my opinion, we need to establish the progress of the global community as a shared communal goal. Considering that the perspectives of humans in the disembedded world have become increasingly individualistic, I think we need to reestablish a sense of community to follow the track toward an “equalitarian” or “right” way to live. I think at present we are very heavily motivated to pursue self-sustainability, however, we lack the realization that the pursuit of such “practicality” is extremely isolating and damaging. I am not trying to say that an individual must not be aware of their needs and take them into consideration, but I also don’t think it is fair to act in a self-centered way. An ideal setup would be one where you benefit from the community’s connections, love, and support, and in return, you act in a socially responsible way. Although this may seem diplomatic, I think the “middle” path is the “right” path for decision-making. My concern with my approach is how can we possibly establish a shared understanding of the “right” path forward when ethics is a very arbitrary concept that is defined differently by different individuals. I think one way of addressing this concern is incentivizing social contribution. Even though this may sound very hypocritical, I think we need to take the first step toward bringing people together and helping them regain interest in communal activities. If we assume the best intentions from all human beings, I am certain that we can move towards a more “balanced” society and establish some sort of shared sense of “ethicality.”

Transitioning from a discussion of the “right” path for society to my personal definition of ethicality, I think I use an amalgamation of my intuition and reasoning to make “ethically and morally” sound decisions. Whenever I am weighing an action or an activity on my scale of “ethicality,” I first begin by examining how it would impact my life and the life of those around me. Considering the consequences of the decision on myself and those around me is the most crucial consideration for my determinants of its “ethicality.” Having considered the implications of my decision, I take my instinctual feelings about a judgment very seriously. Even though I like to be a rational decision-maker and consider the logical reasoning behind my actions, I have had plenty of experiences where I have gone with my gut feeling. I am unsure whether this would mean that I am an emotional decision maker but I accept that my instincts often play an overpowering role in my judgments. Apart from implication and instinctual considerations, I think epistemology does have an impact on my decision-making because I often find myself taking a “leap of faith” when making difficult decisions. These leaps of faith are not typically

based on what has been “proved” to be true but rather on what I believe to be true. To conclude my discussion of ethics, I think an individual's theory of right behavior is an inside-out process. I think the decision of what is right and wrong comes from internal reflection and consideration. Even though it is not possible to create an absolute rule book of what is the “right” or “correct” path to take in a scenario, I do think there can be a set of social guidelines that help us weigh our actions and move forward in the right direction. The theory of right is very internal but to move on the “right” path can be externally/socially motivated.

Aesthetics: What is my theory of beauty?

Beauty to me is a very individualist and yet communal experience. It is fascinating for me to think that although I am looking at the same physical world as other human beings, my interpretation of beauty is different from other individuals. Although this phrase is a cliché, I think “beauty lies in the eyes of the beholder” resonates with my understanding of beauty. Before taking this course, I did not think of experiencing or recognizing beauty as a “transcendental” experience. However, I think I have personally experienced instances where changing my angle of viewing a scenario has deeply altered my perception of the world. My theory of beauty works in three stages and it is similar in structure to Kohlberg’s stages of moral development. My first stage of beauty recognition is termed “filter-free.” This stage lasted from my birth until I was about ten years old. I classify my stages in terms of age because my understanding of beauty has been closely linked to my cognitive development. During my first stage, I think I was freely exploring the beauty of the world but in a protected bubble. This was a stage when I was learning to appreciate the creations of mother nature and how they impact our understanding of reality. I say this stage was filterless because I don’t think I was forced to look at things a certain way or made to notice a certain feature. I was given the liberty of choosing what I considered interesting and beautiful. Even though I was on a filterless exploration, I was not exposed to the “reality” because of the limited surface of interaction. Coming from a super protected environment, my parents really shielded me from the not-so-pleasing parts of the world and at this stage, my perception of the world was probably delusional.

Shifting to the second stage of beauty, I entered this stage during my pre-teen years. The beginning of my exposure to the “reality” of the world brought with it filters on how I see the “beauty” in things. Additionally, the way I perceive “beauty” in actions, art, and other creative expressions is strongly impacted by the emotions I feel when viewing the concerned item. For instance, my interpretation of a piece of art is based on the emotion I feel communicated through the piece along with a consideration of the color scheme, patterns, and other design elements. This is the point of difference between the first and the second stage of aesthetic recognition. If I were to view a piece of art while in the first stage, I would probably see it free of the considerations of design elements, the artist, and a pre-explained way of “looking at it.” The

second stage is my amalgamation of emotion and filtered viewing. Even though in the postmodern world there are a lot of preconceived notions and standards for beauty, I still think I somewhat have an individualistic view of it. I do not think I am completely “materialistic” in my sense of what I consider “beauty.” Furthermore, I also consider myself enchanted in the sense that I believe in the existence of “enlightening” experiences of beauty that help an individual momentarily transcend into what is above the line. I have faith in these experiences and I do think they have the potential of transforming what I consider to be “metaphysically real.”

Transitioning into the third stage, I think this is the stage that I wish to achieve in my understanding of beauty. I consider this stage a way of blurring the lines between the transcendent and the immanent frame. Similar to how we have described “enlightening” experiences for monks and philosophers in this class, I think this will be the stage where I will be able to recognize “beauty” in its purest form. At this point in time, I am unsure if this stage is attainable, however, I think faith will play a huge role in whether I am able to even get close enough to this stage. The contemporary world is becoming increasingly formulaic and we have too many preconceived notions towards any action. I wish to break away from this pattern to view the world for what it truly is. This thought process might be delusional, but I wish to move towards a greater understanding of beauty. I believe that the achievement of this stage will require not only flexibility but also an acceptance of mythos. I think experiences of “beauty” open doors to a plethora of possibilities and enhance our understanding of “reality.” Once I had the opportunity of visiting a very famous Sikh religious shrine, and I felt a sense of strength in myself while I was there. After that feeling, I was able to recognize the “beauty” in some of my religious practices. I am not sure if I would classify this personal experience as “enlightening” but I do think this experience was one where I felt “beauty” shine through in a situation.

To conclude my discussion of the theory of beauty, I do not think that these stages are all exclusive. I certainly see an overlap between these stages and it is the overlap that makes experiencing “beauty” a very personal and fascinating experience. I firmly believe that experiences of true beauty have the ability to change our understanding of what we classify as “good” and “bad,” along with “real” and “delusional.” If the process of experiencing beauty becomes more filtered and directed, I think it loses its importance. I don't think humanity can ever establish ground rules for what classifies as “beauty” or assign a quantifiable amount to “beauty.”